



48 Branded Home PC Test



80 New Ways To Play Old Games



86 Touchscreens

Digital Tools

Technology For Personal And SoHo Productivity

Enhance

Access: Granted

Do you get that sinking feeling when you see all that disorganised data?

Bhaskar Sarma

Every business generates data, and how a business manages it has a significant impact on performance. The traditional method of organising data was by using the humble pen and paper (no wonder they call it book-keeping), and as businesses grew, the increasing volume and complexity of data demanded drastic measures. With the advent of computers came software capable of managing huge databases. Earlier database management programs were tied to specific architectures; later software was standardised to run on all platforms. Oracle, DB2, Microsoft SQL Server, and MySQL are some enterprise-level data management tools.

But these tools are not entirely suitable for the home and the small office segment, because using them requires knowledge of relational database concepts and query languages, which could mean having to enrol in a course! Besides, using software like these to maintain the data generated by a small business is like using a cannon to kill a rabbit—it's simply not necessary.

There is therefore the need for a middle-road software that's simple to use and gets your data-related jobs done. Microsoft Access fits into this category.

Inside Access

Microsoft Access is a database manager. It is part of the Microsoft Office suite and has many versions, the latest being MS Access 2007. Here we have used Access 2003, an earlier version because it has been around for a longer time, and chances are most people haven't been exposed to the newer edition. That said, the essential elements are the same for the two editions, with the only major difference being the user interface.

